

SOF IEO — Topic Deep-Dive: Articles & Prepositions

For Ambar, Class III CBSE

PART 1: ARTICLES (a, an, the)

1.1 The three articles

Article	Use when	Examples
a	one thing, starts with a consonant SOUND	a book, a mango, a university, a one-eyed pirate
an	one thing, starts with a vowel SOUND	an apple, an egg, an hour, an honest boy
the	one PARTICULAR thing, or one-of-a-kind things	the sun, the Taj Mahal, the book I lost

1.2 The golden rule: SOUND, not spelling

This is the single most tested article rule in IEO. - **an hour, an honest man** — the “h” is silent, so the word starts with a vowel sound. - **a university, a uniform, a European** — “u” here sounds like “yu” (a consonant sound). - **a one-rupee coin, a one-eyed pirate** — “one” sounds like “wun”.

1.3 When to use “the”

- Something already mentioned or known: “This is **the** book I told you about.”
- One-of-a-kind: **the** sun, **the** moon, **the** sky, **the** Earth.
- Rivers, monuments, oceans: **the** Ganga, **the** Taj Mahal, **the** Pacific.
- Superlatives: **the** best player, **the** tallest boy.

1.4 When to use NO article

- Games and sports: We play cricket (not “the cricket”).
 - Meals: We eat dinner at 8.
 - Languages and subjects: She speaks Hindi. I like Maths.
 - Things in general: I drink milk every morning. Cows give milk.
 - Most proper names: Delhi, Ambar, India (but: **the** Ganga, **the** Himalayas).
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PART 2: PREPOSITIONS (position and time words)

2.1 The top prepositions of place

Preposition	Meaning	Example
in	inside	The keys are in the drawer.
on	touching the top / a surface	The clock hangs on the wall.
under	below	The shoes are under the bed.
above	higher, not touching	The fan is above our heads.
behind	at the back of	The dog hid behind the curtain.
between	in the middle of TWO	The post office is between the bank and the school.
beside	next to	Ammu sat beside me.
at	an exact point/place	We waited at the bus stop.

2.2 Prepositions of time

- **at** + clock time: at 8 o'clock, at noon.
- **on** + day/date: on Sunday, on 14 June, on Diwali day.
- **in** + month/season/part of day: in June, in winter, in the morning (but **at** night).

2.3 "Between" needs exactly TWO

"He sat between his **two** friends" is right; "between his three friends" is wrong (that would be *among*). IEO loves this trap.

3. Common traps

Trap	Wrong	Right
Spelling, not sound	an university, a hour	a university, an hour
Article before uncountables	She poured a milk.	She poured milk.
Missing "the" for unique things	Sun rises in east.	The sun rises in the east.
on vs in	The keys are on the drawer.	The keys are in the drawer.
on vs at (time)	School starts on 8 o'clock.	School starts at 8 o'clock.
above vs on	The clock is above the wall.	The clock is on the wall.
"reached at"	We reached at the station.	We reached the station.

4. High-frequency IEO question types

1. **Single blank** — "___ umbrella was left on the bus." (An)
 2. **No-article option** — "We play ___ cricket." (no article)
 3. **Double blank (Achiever's)** — "She is ___ honest girl. She always speaks ___ truth." (an, the)
 4. **Error spotting** — "She sat under **an** tree." (an is wrong)
 5. **Preposition from a picture-like sentence** — cat under/on/behind the table.
 6. **Correct-sentence choice** — only one option has both article and preposition right.
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5. Key facts checklist

- a/an is decided by SOUND: an hour, a university, a one-rupee coin.
 - "the" = particular things, one-of-a-kind things, monuments, rivers, superlatives.
 - No article before games, meals, languages, milk/water in general.
 - at + time, on + day/date, in + month/season; at night.
 - between = two things only; beside = next to; above = higher without touching.
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6. Quick drill (10 questions)

1. I saw ___ owl in ___ old banyan tree. (a, an / an, an / an, the / the, a)
2. Mohan waited for ___ hour. (a / an / the / no article)
3. ___ Ganga flows through many cities. (A / An / The / No article)
4. We play ___ football on Saturdays. (a / an / the / no article)
5. The cat is hiding ___ the sofa. (behind / at / between / above)
6. My birthday is ___ 14 June. (in / at / on / by)
7. The aeroplane flew ___ the clouds. (under / above / at / beside)
8. Sita sat ___ her two cousins. (beside / between / at / behind)
9. Find the error: "He poured **a** water into the jug." (poured / a / water / jug)
10. The bus arrives ___ 4 o'clock ___ Monday. (at, on / on, at / in, on / at, in)

Answers: 1. an, an 2. an 3. The 4. no article 5. behind 6. on 7. above 8. between 9. a (no article before water) 10. at, on